

Week 1 Journal: Intro to Well-being

Part One

Before this class, I used journaling only occasionally. I wrote quick notes about assignments, emotions, or a difficult day, but I treated the page as a record rather than a place to understand myself. I also stopped whenever my schedule became busy. Because English is not my first language, I worried that a journal had to sound polished, which made reflection feel like another performance.

The journaling slideshow changed that view. A journal can be a judgment-free space for reflection, planning, awareness, and autonomy. It can use free writing, prompts, bullet points, gratitude, or a hobby. The useful question is whether the practice helps me notice patterns. Writing for a limited time and rereading older entries may show what gives me energy, what drains me, and what I avoid. To participate fully, I need to pause perfectionism, comparison, and the belief that every reflection must produce an immediate solution. Difficult emotions are information, not evidence of weakness.

I have three intentions. First, I will write once a week for fifteen minutes in a consistent place. Second, I will connect events with emotions, body signals, and behavior by asking what happened, how I responded, and what I might try next. Third, I will record small experiments, such as changing my study schedule or protecting sleep, and review whether they helped. These habits support class success and my life outside class because they create a reliable pause and help me notice the effects of my choices.

Part Two: Media Response

The Thrive Global article argues that students often measure worth through grades, accomplishment, and comparison. The story of a student leaving a hospital because she feared missing class made perfectionism concrete. I recognize that pressure from family expectations, my previous education in China, and the wish to prove that I belong at U-M. The article expands success beyond grades to include health, relationships, curiosity, and recovery after a plan fails. I want a protected period before sleep when I stop schoolwork and avoid comparing myself with classmates online. Rest is a condition for learning over time, not a lower standard. A leader who understands personal limits can notice when teammates struggle, listen patiently, and create a group where people can ask questions.

The EDUCAUSE reading also makes me cautious about AI assistance. I will complete a free-write and identify my own examples before using an AI tool. If I use it afterward, I will ask for clarity feedback, compare every suggestion with my experience and course materials, and keep final decisions as my own. Writing the first version myself keeps journaling connected to memory, judgment, and self-care.

Week 2 Journal: Mindfulness and Values

Part One

I chose growth and integrity because they describe the kind of student and person I want to become. Growth means remaining willing to learn, receive feedback, and change direction. Integrity means making my actions match my commitments even when no one is checking. Three behaviors support growth for me: I ask specific questions when I do not understand something, I choose challenges that stretch my skills instead of always choosing the easiest option, and I review mistakes for information rather than treating them as proof that I cannot improve. Three behaviors support integrity: I communicate honestly about what I can finish, I give proper credit to other people's work, and I follow through on small promises such as replying, arriving prepared, or completing a task when I said I would.

There are also slippery behaviors that move me away from these values. Growth becomes unhealthy when I compare my progress with everyone else, avoid a difficult task because I might look inexperienced, or treat feedback as a personal judgment. Integrity slips when I say yes to too many responsibilities and then hide that I am behind, take shortcuts without considering whether I am learning, or agree publicly while privately ignoring an important concern. These behaviors can look productive in the moment, which is why they are difficult to notice. The early warning signs for me are rushing, poor sleep, irritability, defensiveness, and the urge to present a perfect result rather than ask for assistance.

One time I was fully living into both values was during a challenging programming project after transferring schools. I did not understand the assignment as quickly as some classmates, and my first solution failed several tests. My first reaction was embarrassment. Instead of copying a solution or pretending I understood, I wrote down the errors, asked a classmate how they approached debugging, and met with the instructor during office hours. I revised the program in smaller steps and explained honestly which parts I still needed to practice. The final result was not perfect, but I learned more than I would have learned from hiding the problem. That experience showed me that growth requires humility and integrity requires truthful communication.

My family knows these values because they have encouraged me to keep learning while taking responsibility for my choices. A close friend from my previous university also supports them. Support looks like asking how a difficult week actually went, reminding me that a grade is information rather than an identity, and encouraging me to contact a professor instead of disappearing when I am confused. My choice of values comes from family expectations about education, lived experiences of moving between countries, and the transition to a university culture that rewards initiative. These values are not just labels; they are a way to decide what deserves my attention.

My main insight from the values exercise is that wellbeing depends on alignment. When my schedule is full but my actions reflect growth and integrity, I feel tired yet grounded. When I achieve something by hiding mistakes or ignoring my limits, success feels fragile. Mindfulness helps me notice the difference before I react automatically. Emotional intelligence gives me a language for naming frustration, shame, or fear and choosing a

response that fits my values.

I can practice this alignment in small moments. Before replying to a stressful message, I can notice the urge to defend myself, take one breath, and ask which response reflects integrity. Before beginning a difficult task, I can name a growth intention such as “learn one part clearly” rather than “prove that I am already good at this.” These choices turn values into behavior that another person could actually observe.

Part Two: Media Response

The Calm article describes meditation as noticing thoughts and emotions without judging or immediately changing them. That idea is appealing but difficult. My mind often jumps to the next assignment or replays a conversation in English. I may become frustrated that I am distracted and then conclude that I am meditating incorrectly. A nonjudgmental approach changes the goal: success is returning attention gently, not emptying my mind. I can begin with five minutes of breath awareness or the S.T.O.P. practice: stop, take a breath, observe, and proceed.

U-M culture often rewards constant action. Intentionally slowing down can protect my focus, sleep, and emotional stability. A short pause before studying may help me identify whether I am genuinely ready to work or simply anxious. I want to schedule five minutes after lunch or before a long study block, connect it to an existing habit, and treat consistency as more important than duration. Slowing down will not remove every demand, but it can help me meet those demands deliberately instead of allowing urgency to control every decision.

Week 3 Journal: Mental Health, Well-being, and Identity

Part One

As a Chinese transfer student and a junior in computer science, I bring two years of college in China and a different educational culture to my understanding of mental health. I learned to work hard, tolerate pressure, and keep private problems inside the family. Mental health was rarely discussed directly; stress was treated as a normal cost of achievement, and asking for help could look like weakness. My family cared about me, but conversations focused more on grades, sleep, or physical symptoms than anxiety, loneliness, or identity.

On a U.S. campus, counseling, accommodations, peer support, and mental health education are discussed more openly. I appreciate that message, but I still worry about explaining myself in English or being seen as incapable. I now understand mental health as a changing relationship among emotions, thoughts, body, relationships, purpose, and living conditions. Someone can function academically and still need support. Early help-seeking can keep a manageable problem from becoming a crisis; it is responsibility, not failed independence. School emphasized performance, while college speaks about well-being even when its pace suggests the opposite.

Part Two: YouSoup and Story Exchange

YouSoup showed me that “healthy” is not one universal behavior. I used to learn from family, school, and media that exercise and disciplined eating were the clearest signs of health. Those practices may help, but health also depends on time, money, transportation, ability, safety, rest, connection, familiar food, and affordable care. My strongest Story Exchange insight was noticing how quickly I interpret a quiet person as uninterested. Silence may reflect language processing, past experience, or a need for safety. I want to ask curious questions before giving advice and describe my experience without presenting it as the standard. With similar peers I can ask what assumptions we share; with different perspectives I can listen before advising. My education in China and family support are strengths, while language and cultural unfamiliarity can make resources harder to use.

Part Three: Media Response

Rhonda Magee's story about Jake and his family's reaction to an interracial relationship showed me that racism can operate through assumptions, control of safety, and unequal belonging, not only individual attitudes. I felt sadness and anger and noticed tension in my shoulders. Her “Pause” helped me breathe and stay with discomfort long enough to question my assumptions. I will keep learning how race and identity shape institutions and listen before responding. Dr. Stephanie Cook's video connected discrimination to cortisol regulation and chronic stress, while close relationships can buffer stress. Calls with family, study groups, and trusted classmates help me recover when they include honesty and encouragement. Healthier bonds require sharing more openly, listening carefully, and setting boundaries.

Week 4 Journal: Community Well-being

Part One

At first I thought community meant people sharing a place, activity, or identity. I now see it as an ongoing relationship in which members share responsibility for norms, resources, and belonging. Respect, reliability, listening, and sharing information come easily to me. Addressing conflict and speaking when a familiar norm excludes someone are harder. Community well-being requires noticing who can participate safely and who faces invisible barriers.

Before college I belonged to my family, hometown friends, my previous school, and a programming group. Now I belong to an international and transfer-student network, computer science classes, project teams, a study group, and the wider campus. My family offers care but is far away; a study group offers practical support but may focus only on grades. I feel most welcome in a small group that explains concepts patiently and accepts my imperfect English. Fast discussions with cultural references or interruptions make me feel less welcome. The difference is whether the group makes room, not whether every person is friendly.

Part Two

The Academic Wheel of Privilege challenged my assumption that privilege is one personal trait. As an international transfer student, I have access to U-M, technology, and computer science training. Language, immigration status, unfamiliar systems, and cost can still create barriers. I may have campus services but need extra time to understand them and feel comfortable asking. My campus positionality is mixed: people may assume I am technically capable, while my perspective can be overlooked when conversations move quickly. I can bridge gaps by sharing resource information clearly, explaining hidden expectations, inviting quieter members, and challenging jokes that make a group insiders-only. Carin Taylor's ideas of psychological safety, empathy, acceptance, connection, and embracing differences give me a practical standard.

Part Three: Media Response

Giannis Antetokounmpo's response helped me separate an unwanted outcome from failure. I define failure as refusing to learn, repair harm, or reflect before abandoning a meaningful goal. A recent challenge was balancing a heavy computer science workload with new cultural and communication expectations. It has increased my anxiety and made sleep and concentration harder. I cannot control other people's opinions, fixed deadlines, or response times, but I can plan study time, ask questions, attend office hours, break projects into smaller tasks, and protect sleep. My next action is to make a realistic plan and seek help before I feel desperate. The hardest idea this week was that a community can welcome me while remaining inaccessible to someone with another combination of identities. This challenged me because personal acceptance can hide barriers affecting others. Before group decisions, I will ask who has not been heard and offer more than one way to participate.

Week 5 Journal: Success and Failure

Part One

My view of failure was shaped by Chinese education, where exam results, ranking, discipline, and family sacrifice were highly visible. I learned to treat mistakes as evidence that I needed to work harder, but I also learned to hide them because they felt embarrassing. Transferring to the United States added new classroom expectations, English participation, and the need to trust that my previous education still has value. These experiences built persistence but made one poor grade feel like a threat to my identity as a capable student.

Class discussion challenged that belief. Giannis Antetokounmpo showed that one outcome is a step in a longer process. When I feel that I failed, I name the emotion before judging myself. Success may bring pride, relief, gratitude, or confidence; failure may bring disappointment, shame, anxiety, frustration, sadness, or curiosity. I then separate “what happened” from “the story I am telling about it,” contact someone I trust, and choose one small action such as revising code, asking a question, or making a new plan. Protecting my well-being honors my family's effort; I can work seriously without being grateful, quiet, or excellent every moment.

I am learning to distinguish a failed strategy from a failed self. A study plan can be unrealistic, a conversation can fail because I did not listen, and a project can fail because I tested too late. Each result gives information about timing, communication, or preparation. This distinction helps me repair mistakes and speak to friends with compassion.

Part Two: Media Response

Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie's “The Danger of a Single Story” made me examine stories attached to my identity. One story says that a Chinese computer science student should be disciplined, good at mathematics, and willing to sacrifice comfort for achievement. It gave me confidence in persistence but became limiting when it suggested I should not struggle, ask for help, or have interests outside academics. Another story assumes that transferring from China means I cannot understand American culture or make independent decisions. I am also a learner, friend, family member, programmer, multilingual communicator, and person becoming comfortable in a new environment.

Students experience the same classroom differently because identities intersect with language, finances, disability, caregiving, gender, race, prior courses, technology, transportation, and free time. My responsibility is to explain expectations, invite different voices, share resources, notice interruption or invisible labor, and accept correction. Success now means building skill while keeping curiosity and compassion. Failure can hurt, but it can also open a fuller story about who I am and how I want to participate in community.